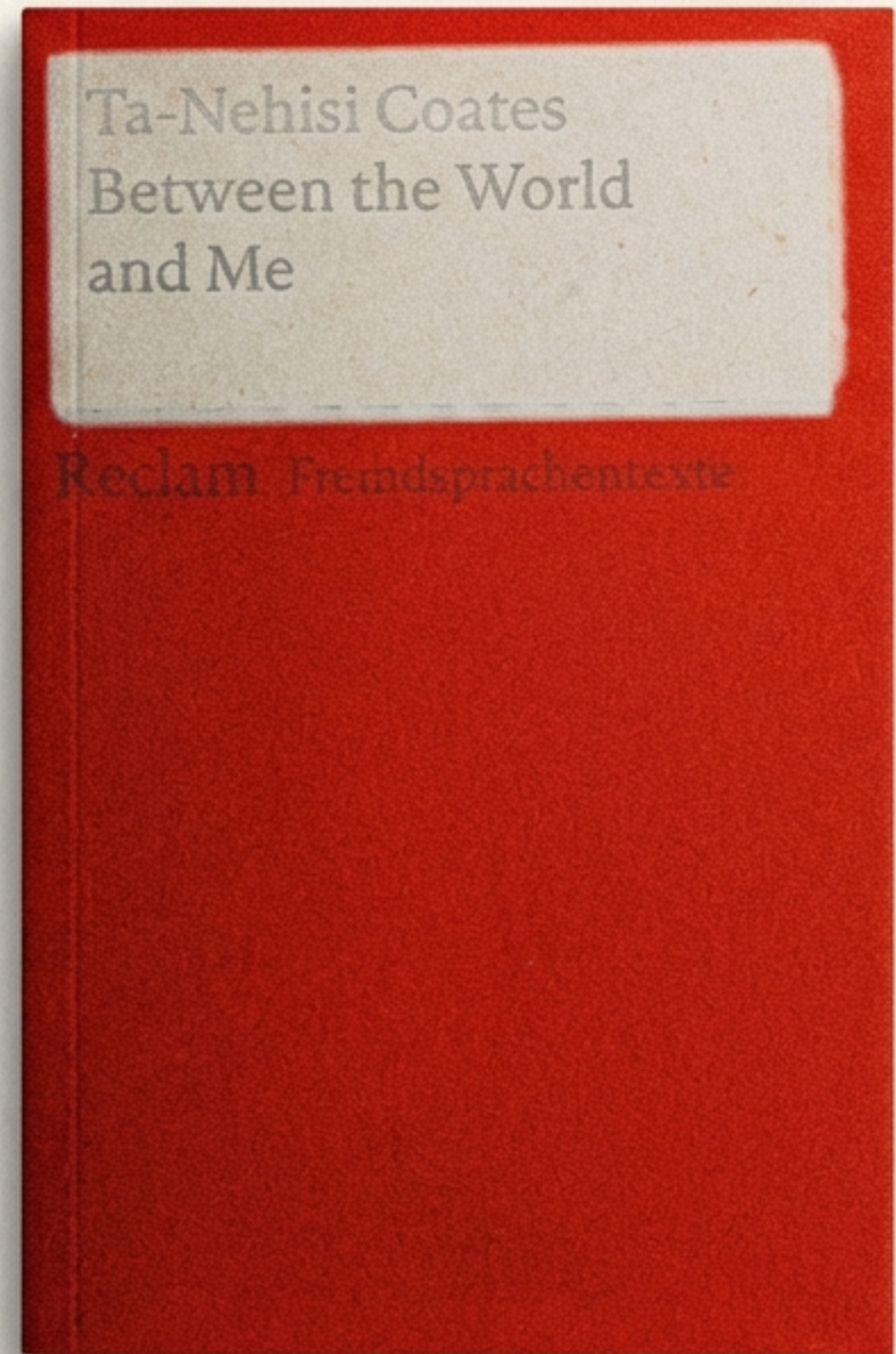


Between the World and Me

*A letter to my son on the
anatomy of a worldview.*

BASED ON THE TEXT BY TA-NEHISI COATES



The Distance Between the Studio and the World

Last Sunday, a host on a popular news show asked me about “hope.” She was in Washington D.C.; I was in a **remote** studio in Manhattan.

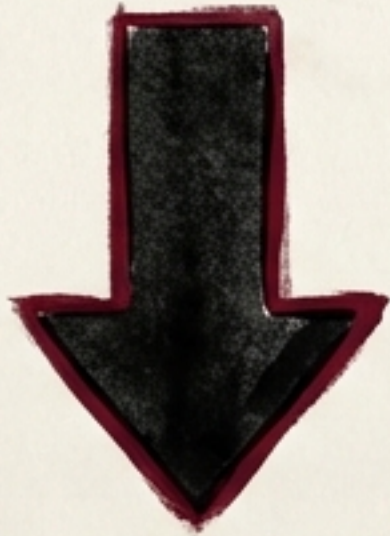
A satellite **bridged** the miles, but no machinery could close the **gap** between her world and the world for which I had been **summoned** to speak.

*She asked about hope.
I wanted to talk about
history.*

IS THERE HOPE?



RACISM



RACE

Race is the Child of Racism, Not the Father

Americans believe 'race' is a defined, indubitable feature of the natural world. This is The process of naming 'the people' has never been matter of genealogy or physiognomy, but of **hierarchy**. The name always implies **hierarchy**.

“Racism—the need to ascribe bone-deep features to people and then humiliate, reduce, and destroy them—invariably follows from this inalterable condition.”

The 'new people' were Catholic, Corsican, Welsh, Mennonite, or Jewish before they were white. They were washed white through the pillaging of life, liberty, labor, and land.

The Dream Smells Like Peppermint

The Dream is treehouses and the Cub Scouts. The Dream is perfect houses with nice lawns. It is Memorial Day cookouts, block associations, and driveways. It smells like peppermint but tastes like strawberry shortcake.

*I have wanted to escape into the Dream... but this has never been an option because the Dream rests on our **backs**, the bedding made from our **bodies**.*

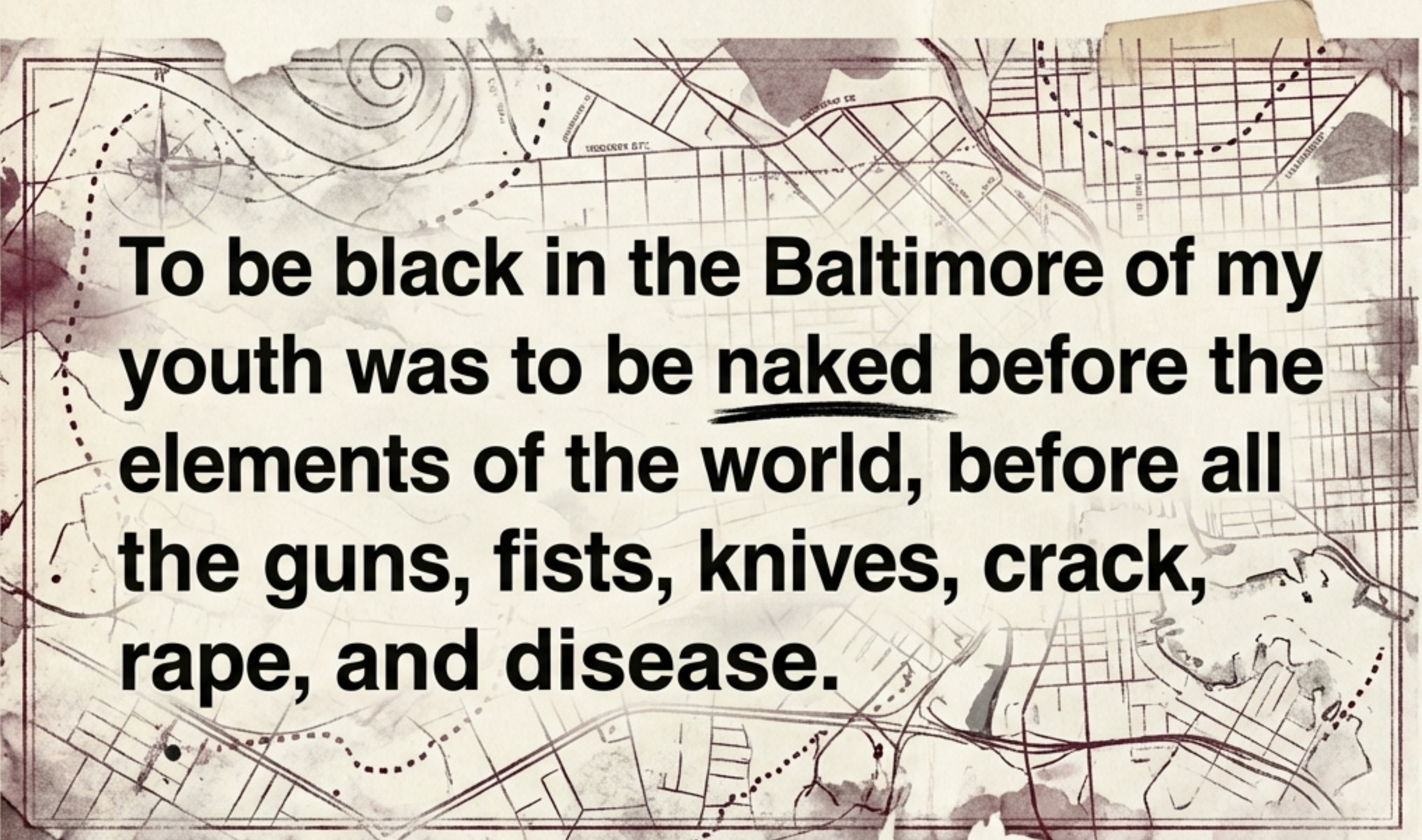


Racism is a Visceral Experience

**DISLODGED BRAINS
BLOCKS AIRWAYS
RIPS MUSCLE EXTRACTS ORGANS
CRACKS BONES BREAKS TEETH**

You must never look away from this. You must always remember that the sociology, the history, the economics, the graphs, the charts, the regressions all land, with great violence, upon the body.

The Galaxy of West Baltimore



To be black in the Baltimore of my youth was to be naked before the elements of the world, before all the guns, fists, knives, crack, rape, and disease.

THE LAW DID NOT PROTECT.

The **nakedness** is not an error or a pathology. It is the correct and intended result of policy. The law was an excuse for stopping and frisking—furthering the **assault** on the **body**.

Armor Against the World



A catalog of behaviors and garments enlisted to inspire the belief that these boys were in firm possession of everything they desired.

I think back on those boys now and all I see is fear.

Either I Can **Beat** Him, or the **Police**!



Love was measured in anxiety. Parents **beat** their children as if someone might steal them away, because that is exactly what was happening.

The **violence** rose from the **fear** like smoke from a fire.

A **desperate** attempt to **save the black body** from the streets or the **police**.

The Two Arms of the Same Beast



If the streets **shackled** my right leg, the schools **shackled** my left.

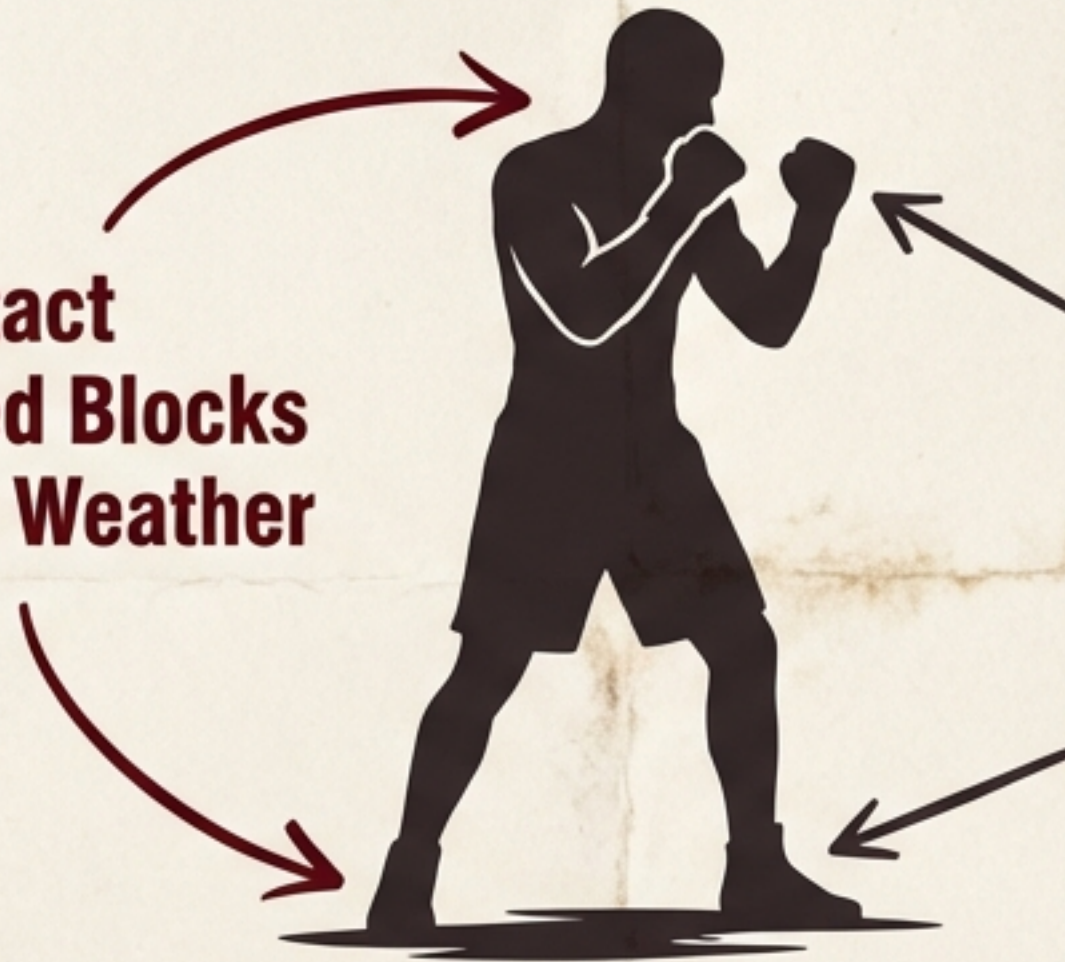
Fail in the streets: Lose your **body** to a crew, a **gun**, the pavement.

Fail in the schools: Lose your **body** to the **penal warehousing system**.

The Lethal Puzzles of the Asphalt

Knowledge

- The **Code of Eye Contact**
- Memorizing **Prohibited Blocks**
- Recognizing **Fighting Weather**



Hands guarding face,
one lower than the other,
cocked like a hammer.

Left foot forward,
right foot back.

The **streets** transformed every ordinary day into a series of **trick questions** where an incorrect answer risked a **beat-down** or a shooting. **Fail in the streets, lose your body.**

Reference: Text describing the fighting stance.

Reference: Text regarding the lethal puzzles of the street.

Education as Containment

Algebra, Biology, and English were not subjects so much as opportunities to better **discipline the body.**

- Prioritizing compliance over curiosity.
- Walking in single file.
- Raising hands to use the lavatory.

60% of all young black men who drop out of high school go to jail. Penal Warehousing.

The False Heroes of February



Why were only our heroes nonviolent?

Every February, schools held a ritual review of the Civil Rights Movement. Teachers urged us toward nonviolence. But to me, these films showed black people loving the worst things in life—dogs that **rent their children apart, tear gas, firehoses**. It felt like a request for **martyrdom**.

Reference: Text critiquing the Civil Rights education.

The Velocity of Escape



I devoured the books because they were the rays of light peeking out from the doorframe.

The Mecca (Howard University)

The Methodology: **Questioning** as a ritual.
Not seeking a settled answer, but a constant state of **interrogation**.

The questions matter more than the answers.

Reference: Text regarding the velocity of escape.

Reference: Text regarding books and questioning.

The Sanctity of the Body



**I loved Malcolm because
Malcolm never lied.**

**He was not mystical. He was a political
pragmatist. He was unconcerned with
making people who believed they were
white comfortable.**

**Key Lesson: Don't give up your life, preserve your life.
Malcolm spoke like a man who was free, like a black man
whose body belonged to him.**

Reference: Text discussing Malcolm X's honesty and appeal.

The Verdict

The week you learned the killers of Michael Brown would go free. You went into your room, and I heard you crying. I didn't hug you, and I didn't comfort you, because I thought it would be wrong to comfort you.



To tell you **"it will be okay"** would be **a lie**. The destroyers of black bodies are rarely held accountable; mostly, they **receive pensions**.

Reference: Text describing the reaction to the Michael Brown verdict.

Good Intention is a Hall Pass Through History

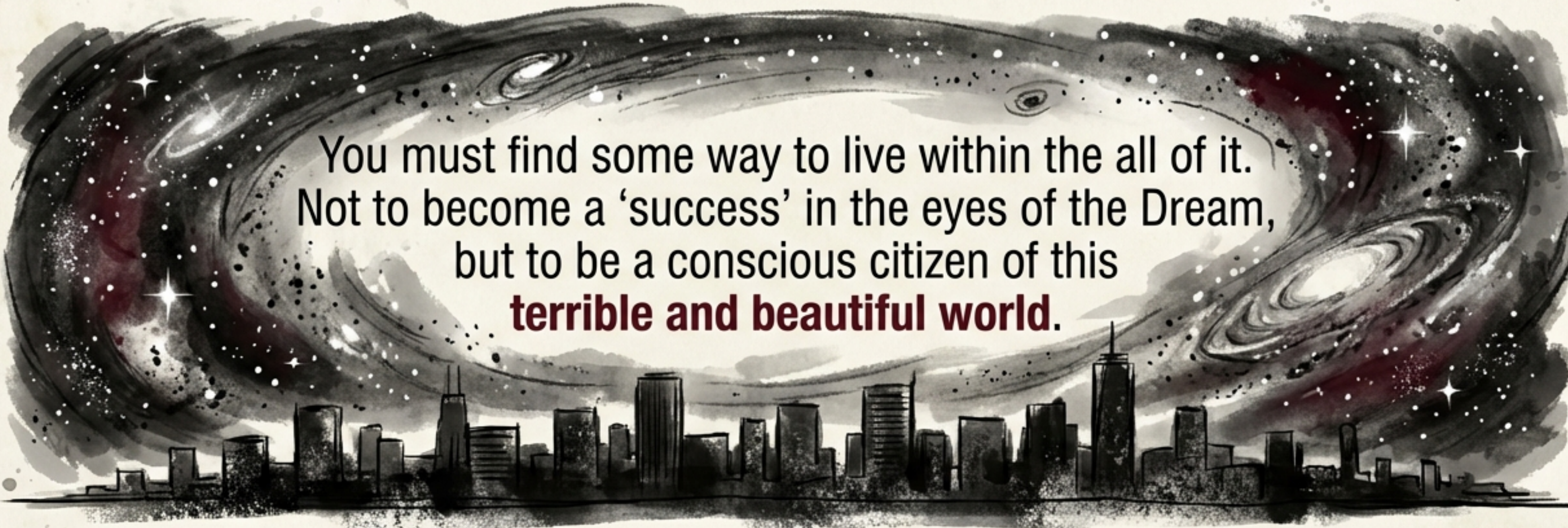


It does not matter if the destruction of the black **body** is a “mistake” or a “misunderstanding.” The excuse is always: “We meant well. We tried our best.”

“Forget about intentions. What any institution, or its agents, ‘intend’ for you is secondary. Our world is physical.”

Play defense—ignore the head and keep your eyes on the body.

The Struggle is the Only Truth



You must find some way to live within the all of it.
Not to become a 'success' in the eyes of the Dream,
but to be a conscious citizen of this
terrible and beautiful world.

"I tell you now that the question of how one should live within a **black body, within a country lost in the Dream, is the question of my life."**

Reference: Text containing the final charge to the son.



**The pursuit of this question, I have
found, ultimately answers itself.**

BETWEEN THE WORLD AND ME